

Amorous amphibians

As the breeding season nears its end, several male European common frogs wait for females in the shallow water of a pond. The frogs are dwarfed by mounds of jelly-covered eggs, or spawn, which other females have already laid in the water. A single female can produce up to 4,000 eggs at a time and these are fertilized externally by a male clinging to her back. At first, the eggs are small, but their clear, jellylike coating absorbs water and swells up, protecting the embryos developing inside. The tadpoles, or frog larvae, take about a month to hatch.

